



Career highlight: The pinnacle of Messi's career came when Argentina won the 2022 World Cup. GETTY IMAGES

become a leader.

But the genius itself remained untouched.

You could ask Josko Gvardiol.

The Croatian defender had been among the outstanding young players of the tournament when Messi isolated him near the touchline in the semifinal. Messi slowed him down, accelerated, checked back, drew him closer, then spun away again. Gvardiol knew exactly where Messi wanted to go but still could not stop him. Messi twisted him through one change of direction after another, carried the ball to the byline and rolled it back for Julian Alvarez to score.

To have lived in the age of Messi was a privilege. To have covered it as a journalist was an outrageous piece of good fortune. We watched him move closer to his destiny from some of the best seats in the house, without paying a penny for them.

His balletic grace demanded better prose from those of us trying to describe it. Anything pedestrian felt like a disservice.

But in the final at Lusail stood Mbappe, the heir apparent, threatening to wrench away the one prize that had always eluded Messi. Every time Argentina thought it had escaped, Mbappe dragged France back. But every time the match threatened to turn into somebody else's story, Messi found a way.

He almost willed Argentina towards the trophy it had

craved since El Diego lifted it in Mexico in 1986.

After more than two hours of football, penalties finally crowned Argentina world champion. Amid the bedlam, the expression on Messi's face was unforgettable. There was joy, certainly, but also relief. The release of a burden carried for 6029 days, since he made his World Cup debut against Serbia and Montenegro in 2006.

But this triumph belonged not just to him or Argentina. It belonged to the Bangladeshi security guard I encountered furtively calling his family from a restroom, overcome by what he had just witnessed. *"Jibon ta sarthok hoye gelo,"* he blurted.

A life fulfilled.

It belonged to the lucky Malayali youngster in the stands, howling into a video call while family and friends screamed back at him from homes and bars along the backwaters and ocean fronts of Kerala.

For a journalist, it was both a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity and a responsibility: to become the tiniest footnote to history by recording it for posterity. Some nights, the deadline is an occupational nuisance. And there are nights when you realise that the words you are furiously typing will become part of how you yourself remember an age.

Four years later, in North America, there he was again.

Messi was older, but the goals kept arriving. And even when they dried up, Argentina kept finding ways to advance through resilience, through teammates, occasionally through the strange interventions of fate, as if football was conspiring to provide an encore.

We were there again, following him and Argentina across another continent.

It took Spain, the country where Messi had learned and perfected so much of his football, to finally stop him.

In the final, a new generation of Spanish footballers compressed the spaces around him and denied him the oxygen on which his game had always thrived. There would be no last escape, no final piece of sorcery. This time Messi could only watch as the World Cup slipped from Argentina's grasp.

He stood with his back to the celebrating Spaniards. Around him, the stadium still sang his name. His eyes welled as if he was beginning to comprehend what everyone else had long been reluctant to contemplate. This long, turbulent, intoxicating love affair with the blue and white was approaching its final pages.

From Kolkata to Kazan, from the despair of Russia to the delirium of Doha and, finally, the heartbreak of New Jersey, I had watched Messi's Argentina journey unfold across 15 years.

And there we were again, journalists hunched over laptops, furiously searching for words worthy of another chapter in his epic.

Perhaps that has always been Messi's trick on those of us paid to eulogise him. After all the goals, the slaloms, the feints, the trophies and the heartbreak, he kept forcing us to search for new language.

Because the ordinary adjectives were never enough for him.